

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 6 · BONUS

Samhain

The Celtic Festival Behind Halloween

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from the hills of Meath to the first “trick or treat”, the people and places you’ll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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SUMMER'S END IN EARLY IRELAND

The hills of Samain

Let's begin on the hills of Meath, at summer's end.



Sites plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Province names are given for orientation only.

AT A GLANCE

- In early Ireland Samain, 1 November, was the doorway from summer into winter
- Herds came home
- Assemblies and feasts were held
- In the tales, the mounds of the Otherworld stood open

Places you'll visit in the episode

Ten places from the episode, from Tara to Coligny.

Tara · Royal hill of Meath and scene of the legendary Feast of Tara at Samain.

Mound of the Hostages · A Neolithic passage tomb on Tara, about 5,000 years old.

Tlachtga · The Hill of Ward near Athboy, a rare four-ringed enclosure about 150 m across.

Uisneach · With Tara and Tlachtga, one of the great assembly places of Meath.

Rathcroghan · Cruachan in Co. Roscommon, where Nera's Samain-night adventure begins.

Oweynagat · The "Cave of the Cats" at Rathcroghan, a medieval entrance to the Otherworld.

Mag Muirthemne · The plain where the Ulster assembly met around Samain in the tale of Cú Chulainn.

Brú na Bóinne · The Boyne tombs, where Óengus and Caer fly as swans.

Blarney · The Cork party of 1832 that Daniel Maclise painted as Snap-Apple Night.

Coligny · In eastern France, where a bronze Gaulish calendar naming SAMON was found in 1897.

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A timeline of the festival

From the hills of Meath to the first "trick or treat", one quiet step at a time.

AT A GLANCE

835
All Saints, 1 November

From 1845
The Famine years

1927
"Trick or treat" in print

c. 3000 BCE	The Mound of the Hostages is built on Tara.
c. 1100–800 BCE	A three-ringed enclosure is built at Tlachtga.
c. 2nd c. CE	The Coligny calendar is engraved in Gaulish, in Roman letters.
431	Palladius is sent to Ireland; Patrick follows.
609/610	The Pantheon in Rome is consecrated to Mary and all martyrs, on 13 May.
c. 799	Alcuin praises Arno of Salzburg for keeping a feast of all saints on 1 November.
835	All Saints on 1 November becomes official in the Frankish realm.
c. 998	Odilo of Cluny institutes All Souls on 2 November.
c. 1100	Lebor na hUidre preserves some of the oldest Samain tales.
1630s	Geoffrey Keating describes a Samhain-eve fire at Tlachtga.
1785	Robert Burns writes "Halloween" in Ayrshire.

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A timeline of the festival

The story goes on from here, slowly.



1790s At Callander, Perthshire, a stone for each person is set by the bonfire ashes.

1820 Washington Irving's "Legend of Sleepy Hollow" and its pumpkin.

1833 Daniel Maclise paints Snap-Apple Night.

From 1845 More than a million people leave Ireland in the Famine years.

1886 A carved pumpkin lantern is reported in Kingston, Ontario.

1897 The Coligny calendar is found.

1927 "Trick or treat" appears in print in Alberta newspapers.

A timeline of the festival

1937–1939 Irish schoolchildren record local customs for the Schools' Collection.

2014–2016 Excavations at Tlachtga reveal ringed enclosures, burning and metalworking.

Early dates are approximate. Excavation cannot show that gatherings took place on 1 November.

One night, many names

Now let's step back and hear the feast's many names.



The feast at the start of November and its names in the Celtic languages, on a modern base map (Natural Earth). "Celtic" here means a family of languages, not one people or one religion. Emigrants later carried the customs to Canada and the United States.

People you'll meet

The heroes, gods and writers you'll meet along the way.

Cú Chulainn · Ulster hero who sees the two Otherworld birds and dreams of Fand.

Fand · An Otherworld woman of the tale Serglige Con Culainn.

Nera · Ailill's man who enters the síd of Cruachan on Samain night.

Ailill & Medb · King and queen of Connacht at Cruachan.

Óengus & Caer · The dreamer and the swan-maiden who fly to Brú na Bóinne.

The Dagda & the Morrígan · Gods who meet at Samain by a river before the battle.

Fionn mac Cumhaill · Stays awake to drive off Aillén, who burned Tara each Samain.

Geoffrey Keating · Historian of the 1630s who described the fire at Tlachtga.

Alcuin · Scholar at Charlemagne's court who wrote of the 1 November feast.

Odilo of Cluny · Abbot who instituted All Souls' Day.

Robert Burns · Ayrshire poet of "Halloween", with its kale stalks, nuts and apples.

Daniel Maclise · Cork-born painter of Snap-Apple Night.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, legend and history

A few things to listen for, and a note on legend and history.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- Nera entering the síd of Cruachan on Samain night
- Óengus and Caer flying as swans to Brú na Bóinne
- Fionn staying awake to drive off Aillén
- Burns's kale stalks, nuts and apples
- A carved pumpkin lantern in Kingston, Ontario, in 1886

LEGEND OR HISTORY?

Some famous claims about Samhain are later inventions: Charles Vallancey's "god Samhain, lord of death" has no evidence, and the ideas of a "Celtic New Year" and an ancient festival of the dead grew from nineteenth-century scholars such as John Rhys and James Frazer. Modern Pagan Samhain is a sincere twentieth-century religion, not an unbroken survival. The episode keeps these apart from what the early sources show.





Artistic impressions of a turnip lantern and of Rathcroghan in mist, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

The Stations of the Sun: A History of the Ritual Year in Britain ↗, Ronald Hutton (Oxford University Press).

Halloween: From Pagan Ritual to Party Night ↗, Nicholas Rogers (Oxford University Press, 2003).

Trick or Treat: A History of Halloween ↗, Lisa Morton (Reaktion Books, 2012).

The Táin ↗, trans. Thomas Kinsella (Oxford University Press, 2002).

The Ancient Celts ↗, Barry Cunliffe (Oxford University Press, 2nd ed., 2018).

Pagan Britain ↗, Ronald Hutton (Yale University Press, 2013).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and podcasts

Museums & places

National Museum of Ireland, Dublin: archaeology and folk life.

Brú na Bóinne Visitor Centre, Co. Meath: Newgrange and Knowth.

Rathcroghan Visitor Centre, Co. Roscommon.

In Meath: the Hill of Tara and the Mound of the Hostages; the Hill of Ward near Athboy.

Podcasts

The Irish History Podcast, Fin Dwyer: Irish history told as stories.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you kept a little light near the door tonight, would it be a turnip lantern or a carved pumpkin?

"At the moment when the dark draws close, they have lit a little light, and kept it near the door."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE, AND FIND THE NEXT ONE

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Dreaming Ages History · Narration is AI-generated text-to-speech; illustrations are AI-generated artistic impressions. Facts follow the episode script and its sources. Maps drawn from real coordinates: Natural Earth; historical borders simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset (A. Ourednik). Free for personal use. Sleep well. 🌙